

# Digital transformation starts at the reception desk

By George Pendapala Natangwe Nekwaya

Namibia is putting serious pieces in place for a more digital public life.

The National Digital Strategy talks about citizen-centred services and closing the digital divide (TechAfrica News, 2025). The Bank of Namibia's National Payment System Vision and Strategy 2030 puts trust, resilience, inclusion and innovation at the centre of how money and services move next (TechAfrica News, 2026).

Those foundations matter.

But most people do not experience those strategies. They experience institutions in a queue, at a counter, when someone asks them to write their name in a book.

Every day, Namibians walk into government offices, clinics, banks, schools, company buildings and worksites. At reception they are often handed a paper register. Name. Phone number. ID number. Vehicle registration. Employer. Host. Reason for the visit.

Then the next person in line leans over the same page and reads it all.

Next to cyberattacks and large data breaches, this looks small. It is not small to the person whose presence at a clinic, a ministry, a bank or a law firm is now visible to strangers.

If an organisation collects personal information from a visitor, the next visitor should not be able to see it.

A shared paper register is more than an admin habit. It is a privacy problem, a safety problem and a trust problem, sitting in plain sight where institutions welcome the public. It is also a sign that digital transformation has not yet reached one of the most ordinary moments of public life.

## **The law is still catching up. The risk is already here**

Namibia's Data Protection Bill is not yet a full data-protection Act. Early 2026 reporting said consultations had closed and the draft was being prepared for Cabinet's legislation committee before Parliament (New Era, 2026).

So the formal framework is still being built.

Waiting for a fully operational Act before fixing an obvious exposure is the wrong lesson. Good practice starts when an organisation notices an unnecessary risk to people and changes the process.

The Electronic Transactions Act already gives electronic records a path to legal effect and evidence, if reliability, integrity, storage and origin are clear (Electronic Transactions Act, 2019). That opens a door. A careful digital visitor process records who is on site, alerts a host, supports an evacuation list and keeps a usable trail, without letting each new arrival browse everyone who signed in before them.

## **Digital should not mean left behind**

In Namibia, inclusion is not a slogan. It is the difference between a system people use and a system people route around.

Replacing a paper book with a process that assumes every visitor has a smartphone, data, an app or a digital ID credential would trade one failure for another.

Plenty of Namibians still use feature phones. Some visitors arrive with no phone. Age, disability, language, literacy and unfamiliarity with screens all show up at the same desk. Rural and low-connectivity sites are part of the map, not edge cases.

So a digital visitor process needs more than one path.

A tablet at reception. An NFC badge for a regular contractor. A QR invitation for someone already booked. Assisted check-in for the person with no device, without sending them back to a shared paper page.

The channel can change. The privacy standard should stay the same.

That is what inclusive digital public infrastructure looks like in practice: a dignified path for the most connected visitor and for the person with no phone at all.

## **Trust is a design choice**

Moving the register onto a screen does not automatically protect anyone.

A digital form that asks for too much, keeps records forever, opens them to too many staff, or pushes sensitive details into casual text-message traffic only relocates the paper problem.

A few design habits help.

Collect only what the visit requires. A delivery needs a name, company, recipient and time. A contractor on a restricted site needs more: sponsor approval, induction, time-bound access. A visitor to a clinic should not be forced to announce medical detail at a

public counter.

Separate "checked in" from "identity proven." A QR code or NFC badge shows someone holds a credential or device. It does not always prove who they are. Match verification to the risk of the place and the visit.

Build for broken connectivity. A rural office should not choose between privacy and keeping the doors open when the network drops. Capture the record securely offline, queue it, notify the host when the link returns, and never claim a host was notified when the message is still waiting.

Keep the process accountable. Who opened a visitor record? When? Why was it kept? When was it deleted? That is respect made visible, not paperwork for its own sake.

## **A practical place for public institutions to learn**

Public-facing institutions are well placed to turn this from a policy talking point into a working lesson.

A controlled pilot at an ordinary reception desk would show what privacy-preserving visitor records look like in Namibia: secure individual entries instead of shared pages, assisted entry for people without phones, NFC for repeat contractors, offline operation, clear retention and deletion, and auditable access.

The point is not to promote a supplier, and not to score any institution's current desk. The point is to see, in one ordinary citizen journey, how privacy, inclusion, cybersecurity and digital public infrastructure meet.

## **Start where people meet the state**

Namibia does not need every law and national platform finished before improving processes that already expose people.

The reception desk is a fair place to begin.

It is where an organisation greets the public, collects information, and shapes a first impression of whether it is organised, secure and respectful.

Digital transformation earns its name when that experience improves for everyone: the visitor with an NFC phone, the contractor with a badge, the citizen with a feature phone, and the person who arrives with nothing in their pocket.

A shared paper register looks harmless.

Do we protect personal information only when a rule forces us to, or because it is the right thing to do for the people walking through the door?

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## Abbreviations

|     |                                                          |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|
| CC  | Close corporation                                        |
| ID  | Identity document                                        |
| NFC | Near-field communication (tap-to-read badges and phones) |
| QR  | Quick response (a scannable code)                        |

## References

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